







TIME TRAVEL (clockwise from far left) works by M.F. Husain, Atul Dodiya and Nalini Malani; a 1940s' photo of the Progressive Artists' Group with its supporters; Shireen, Kekoo and Khorshed Gandhy; (left) Bhupen Khakhar with an artwork

ART

AN EYE FOR ART

Mumbai's **Gallery Chemould**—now Chemould Prescott Road—celebrates turning 60 with a string of seminal exhibitions

The curved white wall imagined by artist Jitish Kallat at Chemould Prescott Road is akin to a black hole, where the fabric of space and time warps and takes you to another moment. It's the mid-'80s, and an eager fourth-grader is led up the stairs near the iconic Café Samovar by her grandmother. They step into a wondrous world of colour and shape, a first for the child but a familiar ethos for the professional artist, a graduate from the Sir JJ School of Art. For the young grandmother, it's a bittersweet symphony, as the work displayed is by artists that were her contemporaries at art school, but who have since moved on from realistic forms to more abstract expressions, while she refused to reinvent. She wants to introduce her granddaughter to the uplifting world of art, but not with her own disillusionment with its ephemeral nature.

Gallery Chemould, at the forefront of the country's art scene since its inception on the cusp of India's Independence and moving to this location on the first floor of the Je-

ART

AN ARTISTIC DUET

An exhibition in Santiniketan showcases the illustrations of **Jatin Sen** that brought the works of the great Bengali satirist **Parashuram** to life

Just as 'Phiz'—Hablot Knight Browne—was to Charles Dickens and John Tenniel to Lewis Carroll, so was illustrator Jatindra Kumar Sen (1882-1966) to Rajshekhar Basu (1880-1960), the chemist, author and lexicographer, considered the sharpest humorist and satirist in Bengali literature. Both writer and illustrator had pseudonyms—Parashuram and Narad, respectively.

Like a laser beam, Basu's wit vaporised window-dressing and exposed societal hypocrisy. He held to ridicule human follies at a time when society was changing radically, and middle-class Bengalis were coming out of their shell to confront their white masters. Women—rarely visible till then—were gradually becoming a formidable presence in public life, and that had an unsettling effect. Basu was unsparing in his attacks, and none escaped his jabs aimed alike at contemporary Bengali society, self-styled godmen, their followers and corrupt businessmen. He rewrote Hindu myths and gave a droll twist to tales derived from canonical texts.

The gallery of life-like characters that Basu's words created became visible through Jatin Sen's confident lines. Sen thereby gave shape to an array of images and physical types that have become inextricably enmeshed with Basu's writings. Sen's iconic images of stick-thin wraiths of both genders that brought to life Basu's masterpiece, 'Bhushandir Mathe' (published in the collection *Gaddalika* in 1924), have become part of Bengal's collective memory. Little wonder both writer and artist won the praise of Rabindranath Tagore.

The artist's original drawings can now be seen at the exhibition, *Vision & Visuals: Jatindrakumar Sen's Illustrations for Parashuram's Stories*,